

needs to be extremely careful to set it correctly to get good photos. The Daylight and Cloudy settings play a crucial role for shooting outdoors. Most cameras that we tested featured more or less the same white balance settings, excepting the Kodak CX7220. It didn't have manual overrides.

In most cameras, a Macro mode, meant for taking extreme close-ups is present. What differentiates one implementation from another is the level of close-up one can obtain. If the subject is as tiny as an insect, most cameras in this category won't capture all the details.

The Canon PowerShot A75 and the Casio Exilim Ex-Z30 allow you to get as close as 5 cm to the subject. However, one needs really steady hands while shooting a subject this close. Weight and stability of the camera are also important.

A light camera, such as the Casio, tends to jerk when the shutter button is pressed, and taking macros gets problematic. The other extreme is equally difficult—if it's the heavy Canon A75, you have to hold it with both hands. This does get awkward at times.

Memory plays a major role in any digital camera. What is the



The Canon PowerShot A75

point of having good optics and electronics if there is not enough storage space in your camera.

How We Tested And Decided The Award Winners

We evaluated the cameras on four main parameters—Features, Ergonomics, Performance and Price Index. The importance given to each parameter varied, depending on the category.

Evaluating Their Features

We awarded points based on the capabilities of a camera, such as its imaging chip resolution, known as the Charge Coupled Device (CCD), its optical and digital zoom capabilities, presence of manual focusing, types of metering modes available, its white balance implementation, the number of flash modes on offer, its shutter speed range, the storage type supported, the nature of its battery, and video-out capabilities. We also awarded points to package contents such as a battery charger, a camera pouch and so on. Software bundled with the camera and support for various operating systems was also considered.

Ergonomics Is Important

We noted various aspects of the camera's build, and looked for features that enhanced its user-friendliness, such as how comfortable it was to hold, the ease with which its user interface could be navigated, the size of its buttons, the placement of the flash (and whether it avoids the finger-over-flash syndrome), and the inclusion of dedicated menu-navigation buttons. The size and weight of the camera were also taken into consideration.

Finally, Their Performance

To evaluate the performance of a camera, we introduced it to a series of tests and evaluated it on preset criteria. The tests are noted as follows.

Mother Knows Best: We created an inanimate test scene to test the camera's ability to reproduce colour and capture details correctly. The mock-up scene consisted of a red motherboard and various slots and connectors in blue, yellow and red. This setup offered a wide tonal range.

Gradation in shading was brought out by a blue sheet in the background, while specular effects (shine) were graded via a shiny metallic audio connector and the motherboard's USB housing. For minute details we looked to the pins adorning the CPU socket, and the walls of the memory and PCI slots.

The cameras were graded on the level of accuracy with which these details were captured. The lighting was kept constant.

The camera was mounted on a tripod, the highest possible resolution was chosen. The camera's flash was used, its other settings such as white balance, metering and flash modes were on Auto.

Dummy Shoot: Here, we took a random bystander and shot a photograph of that person under uniform lighting conditions. If the camera allowed for a Portrait mode, it was used. With cameras that did not have a Portrait mode, the picture was taken in Auto mode. This showcased the performance of a camera under indoor lighting. In the final image, we looked for accurate skin tone reproduction, white balance, uniform tonal reproduction under fluorescent lighting, etc.

Moving Mountains The tendency to be overwhelmed by natural landscapes is high. Especially, since the landscapes are a rare sight in our busy lives. To test camera for this, we shot an image of a mountain covering half the frame, while the rest was taken up by the sky. The purpose of this test was to gauge a camera's performance under natural lighting conditions. Shot in Landscape mode, other settings such as white balance and shutter speed were left to the camera. (Unfortunately the mountain in question is steadily disappearing under quarrying...)

Just Doing It A sport is another visual treat, begging to be captured in various acts of motion. In this test, we tried to capture a fast-moving object such as a car. A Sports mode, if available, was selected. The cameras were rated according to the clarity of the shot. Cameras that returned blurred images lost points.

Extreme Close-up A Macro, in photography parlance is an extreme close-up of an object or a subject. The kind of photographs you would see in an issue of National Geographic demonstrating the pollination of a flower, by an insect, for example. In the Macro test, we tried to capture the tiny grains on a leaf. We got as close to the subject as possible. Here we looked for focused and crisp results. (We await the acceptance of our sample images by NatGeo.)

Taking Price Into Consideration

The price index was calculated taking into account the lowest price for which the cameras are available. More weightage was given to price for low-end cameras as compared to that given to our second, the greater than Rs 20,000 category.

The Awards Process

The score noted from Features, Ergonomics and Performance tests and from the Price Index was given importance as per the specific category. An overall score out of 100 was then calculated. The product that scored the highest in the overall score was adjudged the winner of the Digit Best Buy Gold Award for its category. The runner-up received the Digit Best Buy Silver Award.